

SHOGI · VARIANT 1 OF 4

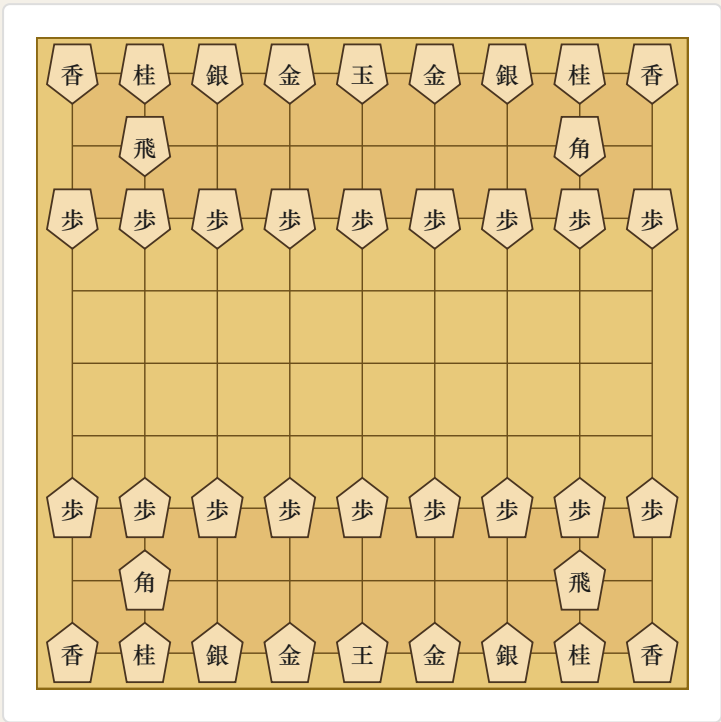
Standard Shogi

9×9
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

STANDARD SHOGI

The full form of Japan’s classic strategy game, played since at least the 10th century. The board is 9×9 and each player commands 20 pieces. The drop mechanic (re-entering captured pieces as your own) defines every decision from opening to endgame.



Standard Shogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 9×9 grid, 81 squares. Traditional boards use natural wood throughout, with no alternating square colours.

Pieces per player: 20, in eight types.

Starting position:

RANK	FILES 9–1 (LEFT TO RIGHT)
Rank 1 — White back	Lance · Knight · Silver · Gold · King · Gold · Silver · Knight · Lance
Rank 2 — White	Rook (file 8) · · · · · Bishop (file 2)
Rank 3 — White pawns	Pawn × 9
Ranks 4–6	Empty
Rank 7 — Black pawns	Pawn × 9
Rank 8 — Black	Bishop (file 8) · · · · · Rook (file 2)
Rank 9 — Black back	Lance · Knight · Silver · Gold · King · Gold · Silver · Knight · Lance

Black (Sente) moves first.

PIECES

PIECE	ABBREVIATION	MOVEMENT
King (/)	K	One square in any of the 8 directions. Cannot move into check.
Rook ()	R	Any number of squares orthogonally.
Bishop ()	B	Any number of squares diagonally.
Gold General ()	G	One square orthogonally, or one square diagonally forward. Six directions total. Cannot move diagonally backward.
Silver General ()	S	One square diagonally in any direction, or one square directly forward. Five directions total.
Knight ()	N	Jumps exactly two squares forward and one square sideways. The only piece that leaps over others. Cannot retreat.
Lance ()	L	Any number of squares directly forward. Cannot move sideways or backward.
Pawn ()	P	One square directly forward. Captures the same way it moves.

PROMOTION

The promotion zone is the three ranks farthest from each player (the opponent's back three ranks). A piece may promote when it moves into, out of, or entirely within the promotion zone. Promotion is optional unless the piece would be stranded with no legal move: Pawns and Lances must promote at the final rank; Knights must promote at either of the final two ranks.

Promoted pieces:

BASE PIECE	PROMOTED NAME	MOVEMENT
Rook	Dragon King ()	Rook moves, plus one square diagonally
Bishop	Dragon Horse ()	Bishop moves, plus one square orthogonally
Silver	Promoted Silver ()	Moves exactly as Gold General
Knight	Promoted Knight ()	Moves exactly as Gold General
Lance	Promoted Lance ()	Moves exactly as Gold General
Pawn	Token (と)	Moves exactly as Gold General

Kings and Gold Generals do not promote.

THE DROP MECHANIC

When a player captures an opponent's piece, that piece is held in hand. On any turn, instead of moving a piece on the board, the player may drop a piece from hand onto any empty square. Three restrictions apply:

- 1 **Nifu** (二歩): A Pawn may not be dropped on a file that already contains an unpromoted friendly Pawn.
- 2 **Uchifuzume** (打ち詰め): A Pawn may not be dropped to deliver immediate checkmate. Dropping to give check is legal.
- 3 **No dead-end drops**: Pawns and Lances cannot be dropped on the final rank. Knights cannot be dropped on the final two ranks. No legal move would exist from those squares.

Pieces always drop unpromoted, even if they were promoted when captured.

WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King: attack the King such that no legal move can escape check. There is no stalemate rule in Shogi. A player with no legal move loses.

DRAWS

Sennichite (三手必死): The same position (including pieces in hand) occurs four times with the same player to move. The game is a draw. If the repetition is caused by perpetual check, the checking side loses.

Impasse (詰り): Both Kings advance into the opponent's promotion zone and neither can be mated. Count material value: Rooks and Bishops score 5 points each; all other pieces score 1 point each (Kings excluded). A player with fewer than 24 points loses. If both players reach 24 or more points, the game is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Standard Shogi. Ancient origin; public domain. Sources: GNU Shogi Manual (GNU Project, public domain); mastersofgames.com rules reference; pychess.org variants documentation.

SHOGI · VARIANT 2 OF 4

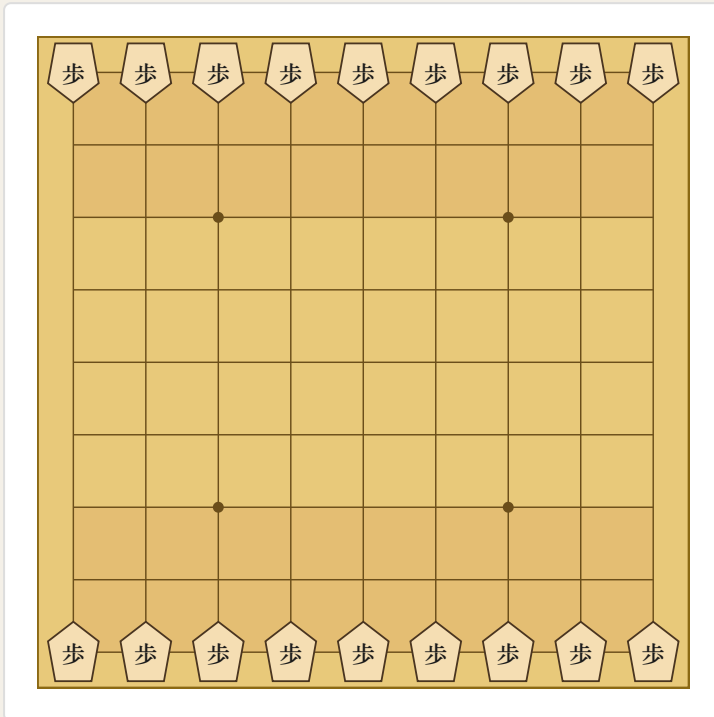
Hasami Shogi

9×9
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

HASAMI SHOGI

Hasami Shogi (はさみ将棋, “sandwiching chess”) is a distinct branch of the Shogi family with a single piece type, no drops, and no promotion. Capture is by sandwiching: a piece is removed when flanked on two opposite sides by the opponent. Ancient origin; public domain.



Hasami Shogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 9×9 grid, 81 squares.

Pieces: 9 per player, all identical. Player 1 places 9 pieces on the nearest rank; Player 2 places 9 pieces on the far rank.

RULES

Movement: Pieces move orthogonally any number of empty squares, in any direction. This is the same range as a Rook in chess. A piece cannot jump over another piece.

Capture (custodial sandwich): A piece is captured when an opponent moves a piece to flank it on two opposite sides along a row or column. The moving piece must close the trap: moving between two opponents does not capture the mover. One move may sandwich and capture multiple pieces simultaneously if several are flanked at once.

Corner capture: A piece on a corner square is captured when both adjacent squares (one on the row, one on the column) are occupied by opponent pieces.

Self-protection: A player cannot lose their own pieces on their own turn. If a move sandwiches a friendly piece between two opponents, that friendly piece is not captured.

No drops. No promotion.

WIN CONDITION

The player whose pieces are reduced to one remaining piece loses.

ATTRIBUTION

Hasami Shogi (Variant 1). Public domain. Sources: [steventran619/Hasami-Shogi implementation documentation](#); [ryan-gallagher-atx/Hasami-Shogi-Game](#) (OSU CS162 final project); [OlliePoole/Hasami-Shogi iOS implementation](#).

SHOGI · VARIANT 3 OF 4

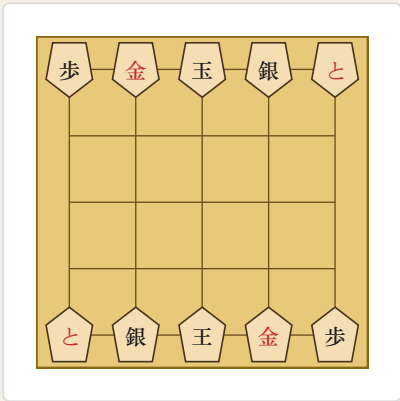
Kyoto Shogi

5×5
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

KYOTO SHOGI

Kyoto Shogi was invented by Tamiya Katsuya around 1976. It is played on a 5×5 board, and every piece except the King represents a pair: after each move, the moved piece must flip to show its other face. The game name plays on the pairing of the Japanese pronunciation of Kyoto (, Kyō-to) with piece name components. Public domain.



Kyoto Shogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 5×5 grid, 25 squares.

Pieces per player: 5 (King + 4 dual-sided pieces).

Starting position:

PLAYER	RANK	PIECES (FILES 5–1, LEFT TO RIGHT)
White (top)	Rank 5	Pawn · Gold · King · Silver · Tokin
Black (bottom)	Rank 1	Tokin · Silver · King · Gold · Pawn

Black (Sente) moves first. The position is point-symmetric (180-degree rotation).

PIECE PAIRS

Each non-King piece has two faces. The piece flips to its alternate face after every move, mandatory.

FACE A	FACE B
Tokin (と)	Lance ()
Silver General ()	Bishop ()
Gold General ()	Knight ()
Pawn ()	Rook ()

Piece movements:

PIECE	MOVEMENT
King	One square in any direction
Token	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward (Gold General movement)
Lance	Any number of squares forward only
Silver General	One step diagonally, or one step forward
Bishop	Any number of squares diagonally
Gold General	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward
Knight	Jumps two squares forward and one sideways
Pawn	One step forward
Rook	Any number of squares orthogonally

THE FLIP RULE

After every move, the moved piece must flip to its alternate face. A piece may be moved to a square from which it would immediately have no legal move (for example, a Lance on the final rank that will flip to a Token on the next turn) — this is legal in Kyoto Shogi, unlike Standard Shogi.

DROPS

Captured pieces may be dropped back onto any empty square. When dropping, the player chooses which face of the pair to place face-up.

WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King.

DRAWS

The same position occurring three times with the same player to move is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Kyoto Shogi. Invented by Tamiya Katsuya, c. 1976. Rules published freely since at least the 1980s; game mechanics are not copyrightable. Sources: pychess.org/variants/kyotoshogi; Fairy-Stockfish variants.ini engine definition.

SHOGI · VARIANT 4 OF 4

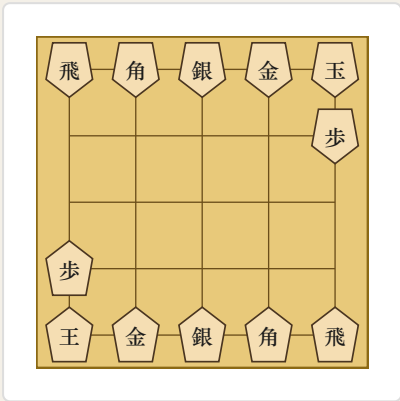
Minishogi

5×5
BOARD

2
PLAYERS

MINISHOGI

Minishogi was invented (or rediscovered) around 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka, Japan. It applies Standard Shogi rules to a 5×5 board, reducing each player’s force to five pieces and the promotion zone to the single back rank. Game mechanics are not copyrightable; the rules have been freely published for over 50 years.



Minishogi — starting position

SETUP

Board: 5×5 grid, 25 squares.

Pieces per player: 6 (King, Rook, Bishop, Gold General, Silver General, one Pawn). No Knights or Lances: the board is too small for their jump.

Starting position:

PLAYER	RANK	PIECES (FILES 5–1, LEFT TO RIGHT)
White (top)	Rank 5	Rook · Bishop · Silver · Gold · King
White	Rank 4	Pawn at file 1 only
Black (bottom)	Rank 1	King · Gold · Silver · Bishop · Rook
Black	Rank 2	Pawn at file 5 only

PIECES

PIECE	MOVEMENT
King	One square in any direction. Cannot move into check.
Rook	Any number of squares orthogonally.
Bishop	Any number of squares diagonally.
Gold General	One step orthogonally or diagonally forward. Six directions.
Silver General	One step diagonally, or one step forward. Five directions.
Pawn	One step directly forward.

PROMOTION

The promotion zone is the final rank only (rank 5 for Black, rank 1 for White). A piece may promote when it moves into or within the promotion zone. Promotion is mandatory when the Pawn reaches the final rank with no other legal move.

Promoted pieces:

BASE PIECE	MOVEMENT WHEN PROMOTED
Rook	Dragon King: Rook moves plus one square diagonally
Bishop	Dragon Horse: Bishop moves plus one square orthogonally
Silver General	Moves as Gold General
Pawn	Tokin: moves as Gold General

Kings and Gold Generals do not promote.

DROPS

The drop mechanic applies as in Standard Shogi. Captured pieces are held in hand and may be dropped onto any empty square on a later turn, unpromoted. Restrictions: no Pawn drop on a file already containing a friendly unpromoted Pawn; no Pawn drop for immediate checkmate; no drop where the piece would have no legal move.

WIN CONDITION

Checkmate the opponent's King. A player with no legal moves loses.

DRAWS

Sennichite: The same position (including pieces in hand) occurs four times with the same player to move. Draw. If caused by perpetual check, the checking side loses.

Impasse: Both Kings enter the promotion zone and neither can be mated. Count material: Rooks and Bishops score 5 points each; all others score 1 point each. A player with fewer than 24 points loses. If both reach 24 or more, the game is a draw.

ATTRIBUTION

Minishogi. Invented (or rediscovered) c. 1970 by Shigenobu Kusumoto of Osaka. Rules freely published since then; game mechanics are not copyrightable. Sources: pychess.org/variants/minishogi; Fairy-Stockfish variants.ini engine definition.